BOOKS

An Apprentice Remembers

Rahul Rawail's unpretentious and intimate biography of Raj Kapoor is a treat to read

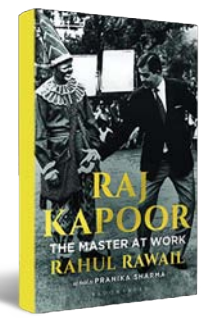


WITH A LEGEND Raj Kapoor (centre) with Rishi Kapoor (right) on the sets of *Prem Rog*

The first time Rahul Rawail—aged barely 16—saw Raj Kapoor in action on a film set, "it was like watching him conduct a symphony." This experience was followed by many others of its type. "I saw the Immortal Master weave his magic," he tells us in his book's prologue; later descriptions include "the puppeteer who deftly manipulated the strings" and "the man who was the epicentre of Indian cinema".

Rawail, a childhood friend of Rishi Kapoor, began assisting Raj Kapoor on *Mera Naam Joker*, and went on to work on *Bobby*—two films, very different in content, tone and scale, that represented a transitional period in RK's career. *Raj Kapoor: The Master at Work* has many stories about the making of these films, along with more general recollections about Raj Kapoor's working methods, quirks, and knowledge of filmmaking.

Here are anecdotes about RK as technician, editor, teacher, director of actors... and as gourmand too, a running theme being his love for food, which led him to go out of his way to catch the Deccan Queen so he could enjoy the train's distinctive meals. (The long editing sessions, we learn, began with everyone spending over an hour deciding on the vast menu for breakfast, lunch and dinner.) Here also are accounts of the "Dambara nights", where iconic scenes from RK films were screened, and of musical *addas* that involved the substitution of obscene "dummy lyrics" while putting together what eventually became gentle, timeless songs. There are analyses of scenes such as the "trilateral shot" featuring the three protagonists in the *Sangam* climax. And there are entertaining asides about the eccentricities of the actor Prem Nath (Raj Kapoor's brother-in-law), who, going by his appearances here, could well have been a solid comic figure in a fictional work.



RAJ KAPOOR
The Master at Work
Rahul Rawail (as told to Pranika Sharma)
BLOOMSBURY
₹699; 245 pages

In terms of writing and structuring, *The Master at Work* is very uneven—with more than its fair share of typos—but its strengths come from the personal, conversational tone. Biographical works are frowned upon when they treat their subjects with dewy-eyed reverence, but this book wasn't intended as an objective study—the lens (or the POV) is a very intimate one. RK Studios, where Rawail began his apprenticeship, was a shrine for the youngster who would later become a director himself—helming some notable films of that unfairly-maligned decade, the 1980s, such as *Arjun* and *Dacait*. Importantly, then, this book is partly about Rawail as well, and not just because it ends with a few chapters about his own, RK-influenced work.

Contemporary Indian film literature—the anecdotal or gossipy variety anyway—is so full of repetition, of familiar stories recycled, that it's a relief to come across a singular perspective. At one point, Rawail tells us that even today when he watches the party scene in *Bobby*, all he can see is two junior artistes gobbling up expensive *pista* and *badaam* that had been provided in rationed quantities, an incident that caused him much stress during the shoot. It's the sort of observation that you could only possibly find in *this* book, and there are many others like it. If this is what a hagiography can be like, bring on a few more. ■

–Jai Arjun Singh